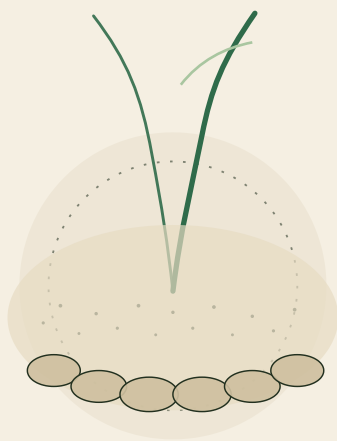




nabta  WELLNESS PARK

THE LIVING SHADE LOOP

DUBAI MUNICIPALITY • AI PARK DESIGN CHALLENGE • DRAFT COMPETITION ENTRY

D•02

Design Narrative & Concept Statement

02 Design Narrative



«نبته» NABTA — Wellness Park

Deliverable 2

Design Narrative & Concept Statement

Concept: The Living Shade Loop

Al Safa 2 · 15,001 m² · AED 35M

TWO CULTURAL ANCHORS: THE SHADE AND THE SPROUT

Before there were streets in this city, there was shade — *dhilal*, the Gulf's oldest wellness infrastructure. The sidr tree at the well, the palm-frond *arish*, the threshold of the **majlis**: each was a small public clinic for body and mind, a cool place where the generations sat at the same level and strangers became neighbours. And wherever water paused in this landscape, something answered it — the *nabta*, the sprout, proof that care compounds into growth. NABTA holds both anchors at once: shade is what the park **gives** on day one; the sprout is what it **becomes** — a canopy, a habit, a neighbourhood's health — year after year. A park that grows wellbeing.

DESIGN PHILOSOPHY: SHADE IS THE INFRASTRUCTURE OF WELLNESS

Every wellness behaviour we want from a Dubai park — the daily walk, the child's hour of free play, the elder's unhurried conversation, the quiet minutes that lower a heart rate — fails for the same reason: for five months a year it is too hot to begin. So we refused to treat shade as an amenity. In NABTA, **shade is the program**. The site itself set the geometry: an irregular sixteen-vertex parcel of **15,001 m²** in a roughly **120 × 178 m** envelope, its street edge to the south and its grid rotated about 47° from north. Onto it we lay an **858 m continuous shade network** — a **398 m figure-eight** braided into a **460 m perimeter ring**, stretching to roughly a kilometre with the wadi spur — designed first as a ribbon of thermal comfort and only second as a track. Dense native canopy (ghaf, sidr, date palm) alternates with AI-form-found pergolas where trees cannot close the gap. Our verified target: **92% of the loop shaded at 3pm in peak summer**, delivering a **-4.5°C perceived temperature** (UTCI) against the adjacent street. Comfort is the precondition of health: minutes of comfort convert directly into minutes of movement, restoration and company.

A LOOP OF TEN ROOMS, THREE MODES OF WELLBEING

The Living Shade Loop is the park's social condenser: the figure-eight for laps, the perimeter ring for the long stroll, and jogger, grandmother, toddler on a balance bike and teenager sharing one shaded spine at different speeds. Threaded onto it are **ten garden rooms**, organised by what they do for a body:

- **Move:** the loop itself; outdoor fitness grove with elder-friendly low-impact stations; teen active zone; inclusive play dune graded by age and ability — physical literacy from two to eighty-two.
- **Restore:** quiet contemplation garden screened by planting, not walls; sensory wadi garden along the bioswale, where falling water and native fragrance do the work of a therapy soundtrack; family picnic groves for unstructured rest.
- **Connect:** entry plaza, community majlis plaza and event lawn — the intergenerational rooms, sized for prayer-eve gatherings, weekend markets and National Day evenings; café terrace at the loop's golden-hour edge.

Rooms hold sightlines into their neighbours — a parent at the picnic grove watches the play dune; elders in the majlis overlook the plaza — so caregiving is ambient, not confining. The park breathes on a day-to-night rhythm: dawn runners, late-morning shade for infants and their minders, misted pergolas through the afternoon, then the true prime time — evening — when warm, dark-sky lighting turns the loop into a

promenade. The wadi bioswale, fed by AC condensate and treated water, makes sustainability touchable: children learn where water comes from by following it to the newest sprouts.

HOW AI SERVED THE DESIGN – HONESTLY, AND IN NUMBERS

AI did not design this park; it let us test more convictions than any team could by hand. Solar, wind and UTCI simulation across 8,760 annual hours shaped the loop's geometry and canopy density; generative design produced forty-plus masterplan variants scored on shade continuity, walkability and irrigation demand; agent-based models of five user personas stress-tested sightlines and evening crowding. The decisive judgements – the majlis at the heart, a room of the teenagers' own, the café facing the sunset – were human, cultural and debated aloud. We used AI the way a falconer uses the wind: to go further in a direction we had already chosen.

GROWING WITHIN AED 35M

The nabta principle is also our delivery strategy: plant the structure, let value compound. Roughly 40% of the budget goes to the path network, pergolas and shade structures – the permanent wellness infrastructure; 30% to landscape, soil and the ten rooms; 15% to water systems (bioswale, condensate recovery, subsurface drip for a native palette needing a fraction of turf's irrigation); 15% to lighting, furniture and sensing. Trees are installed young and inexpensive because the shade model proves pergolas carry comfort until canopies mature – the park is fully usable at opening and measurably better every year, with falling, not rising, operating costs.

VISION

We are planting 858 metres of continuous shade – a kilometre with the wadi spur – and calling it a promise: that in Al Safa 2, no one must choose between the heat and their own health. Walk the loop at maghrib – past the children on the dune, the elders in the majlis, the water finding the youngest roots – and you will feel what the Gulf has always known: where there is shade, things grow; where things grow, people stay well.

